

Interviewer: So, before we start, how would you like us to refer to your partner?

Participant: I don't know; you can use the first letter of their name, it's a [letter].

I: Okay, very well, [letter]. So, how long have you been with this person?

P: It's been... well, it will be [1-5] years in [Month], so [1-5] and a half years, something like that, well [1-5] years in [Month], so [1-5] and a half years, something like that.

I: I would like you to talk about your relationship, your story, the relationship you currently have.

P: Yeah, okay, so to start with the details, I am in the [Country] now, she is in [Continent], in [Country] and [Country], so for these [6-10] months, it's a long-distance relationship, it just started, let's say, this long-distance relationship since I arrived in early [Month]. And otherwise, I think that... well it's very early to say since it's only been [1-5] weeks since I arrived here, but I feel like not much has changed; it's still the same relationship, I would say. And so, to describe this relationship a bit, despite the distance, but I don't think the distance is a big factor apart from the lack we might feel for each other, each on our own side. It's a relationship where very quickly, the first time we met through friends, very quickly, I just felt like it was easy to talk to her. I felt like it was easy for me to confide in her, which is not necessarily the case with everyone; I'm usually someone who is reserved. She also brings me a lot in terms of... well, we share the same interests for certain things, but she may have an easier time or a higher interest in new experiences and reaching out to others, while I am more reserved. And even though we enjoy doing the same things to some extent, like outdoor activities, multi-day hiking, running, trail running, etc., I find that in these activities, I have to be more focused on how I feel internally about doing the activity itself, etc. I have fun, one could say, with the terrain, with the landscapes, and she is much more focused on other hikers, meeting local people if we are abroad, etc. And so there's really this idea that she helps me open up my horizons, that's what I was looking for too. She brings me a lot in the sense that... how do I put this? She encourages me a lot. For example, you might imagine that for this stay abroad, she could be bothered because it affects her; of course, it saddens us in a way, but well, it's a temporary stay, and she was very open to the idea that I could benefit from this experience. I'm doing a thesis, and coming to study in a lab here in the [Country] for [6-10] months was a very good opportunity following a scholarship I received to approach my thesis from a new angle, so with neuroscience. And she was very quickly, very open, and encouraged me a lot. Similarly, with hobbies, running, and all that, she really motivates you to do what you want to do and not to put barriers like other people or other relationships I might have had before, because she's not afraid that I might be less interested in her, that it might prevent us from spending time together, etc. And anyway, I feel like she wants me to do what's important to me and not sacrifice my individuality for the couple, like I run a lot, that's another example. She will also encourage me when the weather is bad, when I don't feel like running, maybe watching a movie together is better and all that, she will also tell me no, go ahead, you have to run this many kilometers this week, you have to do it. So, she encourages me a lot, she supports me, she's very generous in that sense, and she opens me up to new horizons in her relationship with others. She has a

very easy relationship with others, while I am more wary of strangers, for example, and she more easily gives people the benefit of the doubt, she listens more easily, whereas I am more closed off to strangers. So, I think that's what she brings to me. Do you want me to say what I think I bring to her, or do you have other questions?

I: Yes, but there's no right or wrong answer; I'm here to gather your thoughts.

P: It's just that I talk a lot, and then I tend to forget the original question.

I: This was really just about describing what you want to say about your current relationship.

P: Yeah, okay, so to move on to what I think I might bring, it's always a bit more delicate because ultimately, in a way, I don't know. I just hope it's enough and that I hope to be able to give back everything she brings me. Maybe I bring her more serenity because she's a slightly more anxious person, and I'm the opposite, rather very calm. More serenity, more self-confidence too in relation to certain difficulties she might have professionally. I'm a good listener, so I'm always there to listen when she has these doubts that might generate some stress. I'm very solution-oriented, in the sense that if there's a problem, my mind immediately thinks, okay, to solve this we could do this or that. And I know that sometimes she just needs someone to take her side, so I try to alternate between these two modes: finding a solution and acting to solve the problem, and then times when it's maybe just about listening without trying to solve the problem. And yes, because she's more open to new experiences and all that, sometimes she might have a hard time channeling her energy on one goal, one project, one thing. And I'm the opposite; I plan to run a marathon on [Date], and I'm training for that, just to give an idea. So maybe by being with me, she manages to settle down, to better plan how she's going to achieve the various goals she wants to achieve. For example, I take a simple example like running, it's simpler, but she also wants to run a marathon one day. So, she needs to figure out how to train for that without overthinking it, we're not professionals, but there are certain things to put in place, and it takes time and energy. Prioritizing some things over others to achieve these goals without spreading oneself too thin might be something I can help with. Then, in terms of how I see my relationship with her, the other question I imagine is how I project the relationship into the future, what will it look like from now on. We have professional situations where we're still looking, we're in our thirties, so we're still looking, we're not settled. Despite these uncertainties we have, because neither she nor I have a very stable professional situation. In fact, I think we'd both be out of place in a very stable professional situation. Ah yes, another thing is intellectualism. I'm a very intellectual person, and so is she, but not necessarily on the same things. There's also a kind of complementarity that I really appreciate. As for the future, despite our typical academic background, something I would like for the future is to manage to get closer geographically. I don't want to do a postdoc in the [Country] for [1-5] to [1-5] years, for example. That's something I know pretty clearly because it would be too restrictive. I want to be with her, and for us to continue this relationship.

I: Very well, I'd like you to talk to us about, if you had to compare the quality of your current relationship with the quality of your friends' relationships, what would you say?

P: Friends... I have a lot of single friends who are kind of experimenting, some women. I have friends who absolutely don't want to be in a relationship, and among my friends who are in relationships, it's complicated because I have people who are thinking about marriage, who are going to get married, so who are very stable in their relationships. The goal, the question here is really to compare. Can you repeat the question just to be clear?

I: It would be to compare the quality of your relationship with the quality of your friends' relationships. What do you feel differs between their relationships and yours?

P: Okay, okay, because quality, I can't judge the quality of others' relationships; they know best. After comparison, it's a very difficult question. I would say that compared to some couples, these are very specific examples that come to mind. I hope there is more listening to each other's desires. I listen to her more, and she listens to me more than this couple I have in mind where the man seems, from an outside perspective, to be a bit in the background, and the woman has her ideas and plans. If he wants to follow along, great, if not, too bad. I feel like maybe we aren't like that, even if we encourage each other to pursue our own goals. I think we discuss the impacts and desires of each other more compared to another couple. What else changes? I think we do a lot of things together compared to my sister, who seems to do more things individually with her future husband. They are more each in their own corner. Of course, it's very healthy to be able to do things without the other, but I think something that changes is that we share a lot of interests and try to experiment with each other's interests. We are both very curious, so we are always willing to go, well mostly willing, to experiment with the other's desires. For example, if she wants to go to an exhibition in a museum, I'm not very museum-oriented, but because there's always this idea of exploring what interests her and spending time with her, I might enjoy going to the museum. We both enjoy going to the theater, watching movies. We share the same taste in films. In reading, we diverge a little; during the summer, I want to read more fantasy, things that help me disconnect from work, from more serious concerns that other novels might raise. She likes biopics more. So we each have our own interests, but I feel like we still move towards each other a lot. And it's maybe when I think of my sister and her relationship with her future husband, they are more each in their own corner. Of course, it's very healthy to be able to do things without the other, but I think something that changes is that we share a lot of interests and try to experiment with each other's interests. We are both very curious, so we are always willing to go, well mostly willing, to experiment with the other's desires. For example, if she wants to go to an exhibition in a museum, I'm not very museum-oriented, but because there's always this idea of exploring what interests her and spending time with her, I might enjoy going to the museum. We both enjoy going to the theater, watching movies. We share the same taste in films. In reading, we diverge a little; during the summer, I want to read more fantasy, things that help me disconnect from work, from more serious concerns that other novels might raise. She likes [topic] more. So we each have our own interests, but I feel like we still move towards each other a lot. And it's maybe when I think of my sister and her relationship with her future husband, they are more each in their own corner. So obviously, it's also very healthy to be able to occupy oneself without the other, but I think something that changes is that we still find ourselves on a lot of the interests that interest the other because we are both very curious, so we are always willing to go, well mostly willing, to experiment with the other's desires. For example, if she wants to go to an exhibition in a

museum, I'm not very museum-oriented, but because there's always this idea of exploring what interests her and spending time with her, I might enjoy going to the museum. We both enjoy going to the theater, watching movies. We share the same taste in films. In reading, we diverge a little; during the summer, I want to read more fantasy, things that help me disconnect from work, from more serious concerns that other novels might raise. She likes biopics more. So we each have our own interests, but I feel like we still move towards each other a lot. So the main points are already listening to each other and also sharing interests. I think that's something we try to do more or less naturally, and it's something I think I want to stay attentive to in the future to not... how do you say... to not take this relationship for granted, to not say, yes, we run together, that's what we do. Because maybe one day I'll lose interest in running, I doubt it, but maybe one day she will lose interest. So yeah, staying... not vigilant because it's a bit anxiety-inducing to say we need to stay vigilant, but staying attentive to how our interests evolve and what's attractive to the other and to take an interest in it too.

I: And if you had to compare to your previous relationships, what would you say about it?

P: The very first thing I mentioned was really the fact that it's someone you can talk to and who is very attentive and who encourages me, and those are really the things that change compared to other relationships I might have had, where other partners were... how do I say this? The previous one, she put up more barriers regarding... I don't know, she had a problem with running, typically, because her father used to run a lot, and she thought that her father's training facilitated the divorce, etc. Whereas, well, I think there were a whole lot of other problems beyond running, especially since I wasn't running much at that time either. So 30 km a week is nothing, but already there was this kind of... oh, you're going running again? This kind of control, you're going running again, but if you start a doctorate, that means you won't have a stable situation. So you could feel there was something wrong because she had her own idea of the path she wanted, and I felt like I was someone who... either you graft onto this path and do what it takes to respect it, so you limit hobbies that might be potentially disruptive, you choose a career that fits the idea she has of the life trajectory, etc. And if you don't do that, there's a problem. So yeah, that's something quite unpleasant for me, who needs independence. And so my current partner gives me that sense of freedom and to do what I want. Of course, if I tell her I want to live for [1-5] years in a cabin in [Location], it's too much. But I am relatively free, and I still want to thrive in this relationship. Another thing, rather on her side, which changes from previous relationships, is that she is very attentive to her feelings, her sensations, and when she reaches the point where she... quite quickly, actually, when she knows what she wants, what she needs. Similarly, it's up to me to also give her that freedom. Which I find, when you are someone who needs that freedom, giving it back to the other is also easier because I think we understand each other very well on this level. So compared to other relationships in the past, I feel like she knows more, she knows better what she needs than other people. She is more attentive to her feelings than other people, hence the importance of listening to her because it's something she will communicate, whereas other people in the past had a whole level of resistance they weren't even aware of or sensitive to, so we never talked about it.

I: So there's this notion of freedom that differs from your past relationships. And can I ask how many partners you've had in total?

P: Yeah... not many, if we're talking about serious relationships with a duration...

I: What do you consider a relationship?

P: Well, I've had long relationships right from the start. I started having long relationships very early, so... I would say this current relationship must be the [1st-5th] or [1st-5th], depending on whether I include someone or not in these long relationships. I think it's the [1st-5th].

I: I'd like you to talk about what a high-quality relationship is for you.

P: A high-quality relationship... ideally, I think it's... I imagine you've heard this a lot, but being able to talk without fear of how the other will react, to talk about doubts, fears, and feel supported, listened to at first, and then supported. There's also this notion of individual freedom. I think, in her case, she saw firsthand her mother completely deprived of this freedom. Her mother completely sacrificed herself for her husband, his career, and family life, and that's something she absolutely doesn't want. And from my side too, I have lots of desires to feel that we can undertake all the things we want without the other feeling threatened by the time our projects might take. Of course, while maintaining that balance, we still want to be in a relationship, so if we both pursue our projects on opposite sides of the globe, it's not desirable either. So there's this desire to preserve the complicity we can have, common activities while maintaining this part of individuality. I think these are three things: communication, the fact that we can be individuals, and there's still a kind of complicity that makes a relationship high-quality, as we say. And how can we know we're in a relationship that combines these three aspects? I think the scientist in me would say, oh yes, we need to look at how often we address delicate topics, how many things we did together this year. I think it wouldn't be a good idea to go down that path. But simply, I think we know in a more intuitive way, reflecting on how we feel in this relationship. And I can say today that we have these three things. I can also say that... these are things we have, but also things we need to pay attention to continually. We can't really stop. And of these three things, like for many others, the most complicated is also communication, especially now that I'm abroad. So trying to find moments where we can still call and discuss things, not so much events but more ideas concerning our relationship. Finding the time to do that, I would say, is the point that suffers a bit now. But I think each person, by being a bit attentive, should be able to know how to position themselves in terms of these levels, where the relationship stands on these different points.

I: And when would you say your relationship was most close, for example? Most communicative?

P: Several things come to mind. I have in mind several moments, like when we take the time to spend time together, like the simplest is a dinner at a restaurant. We can discuss these things, what we want, etc. Very quickly, talking about our past relationships since we both came out of relationships that generated some dissatisfaction. Finding ourselves and being able to discuss them openly, I think, already created a strong complicity at the beginning. Then there are the different trips we can take together, the projects we have that we both desire, like hiking in [Location] or climbing certain mountains. These moments open the door to this complicity. It's

not that we are completely complicit during the [11-15] days we took to cross [Location]; it doesn't work like that. But just taking the time to do these trips we both want gives us the opportunity to experience a certain difficulty, to see how the other reacts to fatigue or sometimes lack of food, sleep, etc. All these experiences help build this complicity. I also see it when we can anticipate each other's desires or state of mind because we observe their behavior and know if something is wrong or anything. So I would say that in our relationship, there was the beginning where it was very close, but also, we often experience this complicity thanks to our common desires and different projects. So spending time together and, as you said, anticipating the other's needs, yes, I feel close when we discuss. I gave positive examples where we are at a restaurant, discussing things, and feeling good because we can share with someone because we are on vacation and walking across a country. But there are also more difficult moments, like when work isn't going well, and we're tired, fed up with our jobs. Knowing we can talk with the other highlights the complicity we have.

I: And are there times when there was less complicity?

P: Less complicity?

I: Yes.

P: Yes, yes, well, I can talk mostly for myself, but typically the moments when... actually no, I feel like it's not true. I was going to say the moments when there's a deadline, something to submit for work, like writing a project proposal, applying for funds, which can take a lot of time, so there's a kind of closing in, at least that's how I function, focusing entirely on that project. There might be [1-5] or [1-5] weeks where we are completely centered on that; it becomes our main activity. But actually, no, it's false because I remember she was still there encouraging me, and it's something I talked to her about, how we experience these moments of intense work. So I was going to say, yes, if there's a lot of work, then maybe the complicity... but I think it's not quite right either. So I'm looking for another example of when there might be less complicity. Maybe still, during those times, comparatively, there's less, but I don't think that means there's none. If I can answer like that, I'll stick with that.

I: No problem. On the contrary, I'd like you to talk about what a low-quality relationship is for you.

P: A low-quality relationship... the first thing that comes to mind is one person wanting to control the other. To me, that's the saddest thing. So the poorest relationships have this notion of control. Then it's more or less pathological; there's control, emotional blackmail. I think we've all heard some stories; it's the cousin of a colleague who is in a very complex situation, and I think those are the worst relationships. And how can we know we're in a very controlled relationship or being controlled? It's not an absolute answer, but I imagine the day you think I'd like to run around this island and wonder if you have the right, that's not a good sign. If you're afraid to talk about your desires to your partner, that's a bad sign.

I: Do you feel there was a time when your relationship had that aspect?

P: No.

I: Okay, I'd like you to talk about the most important things for you in a romantic relationship, apart from communication, complicity, and individuality.

P: Could you repeat the question?

I: I'd like you to talk about the most important things for you in a romantic relationship.

P: I would say it's a bit of what I just mentioned, that there's no control, that everyone feels free to some extent, that we can talk about difficult things, things that are going well, but also more complicated things, and be there for the other when things aren't going well, being available, paying attention to the other.

I: So freedom and paying attention to the other. I'd like you to talk about, from your experiences, what love is for you, whether in a couple or in friendship, in general.

P: Love... I think it's... it's a complicated question. I was going to start with the trust we can have in someone. So for me, it's something important, knowing that these are people, at least for certain things, who are responsible. What I mean by that is being able to trust a friend when... I was going to say when we ask for help and all that, but we're rarely in situations where we really need a friend's help. But beyond that, having benevolent people, I would say. Again, it comes back a bit to control and all that, but I think it's easier to love, to feel good with people who are benevolent, who are honest, who don't play a double game, and who are transparent. That's something super important to me. I don't think I could be friends or in a romantic relationship with someone who isn't straightforward.

I: So love would be a mix of honesty, trust, benevolence?

P: Yes, it seems like a basic dedication, but I think that's definitely part of it, maybe other things I forget too.

I: And how important do you think love is in a relationship?

P: I would ask what you mean by love, actually. Once we try to define it, it's also a complicated word, whether we take a philosophical or physiological approach. Could you repeat the question again, please?

I: How important is love in a relationship? You can base it on what you said in the previous question.

P: For me, if there's no form of love, which can be unique to each individual, it's a relationship that doesn't really have any interest. No, I wouldn't be in a romantic relationship with someone I can't feel love for, obviously. And similarly, I wouldn't spend a lot of time with people, friends if they aren't really friends. This thing... again, unique to everyone, but I think maybe I have relatively... I like to keep my friends close and spend time with them and do things with them. So

having a rather small circle of friends with a few individuals rather than having 150 friends but not really having shared anything with them. I think sharing something, it could be discussing things again, ideas more than facts. If we have someone we go for a drink with and talk about... what series have you watched lately, if we don't move on to the ideas the series might convey, more like discussing concepts rather than just facts. That's something where I won't be super satisfied with just going through facts and reviewing several domains: sports facts, artistic facts, geopolitical facts, etc. So to go back to the question, I think it's essential to share experiences, feelings, to talk about them, and these friends and relationships we love are essentially based on that. If there's no love, a relationship fades quite quickly, I think. Love is important, but there needs to be something else alongside it. I think that's love; I don't know how to distinguish between that idea of being transparent about feelings, sharing experiences with others, and separating it from love. I don't know where the line is. Let's say there's an attraction at the beginning when we don't know the person yet. There can be an attraction very quickly, and then things start to add up, whether it's identifying common points, opening up a bit, and liking the other's way of thinking. That's also something we can love. So I'm not sure how to separate love from all that. I think all these things that stem from an initial attraction are integral parts of what love could be, these deeper interactions make up love. Because we can also... and that's where it broadens horizons a lot, because we can also learn to love someone. So here, I'm talking... it's true that I'm probably talking more about friendships, where in the first two or three meetings, we don't feel super close to the person, but after a few more interactions, a few particular situations, there's something interesting about someone we can learn from and feel closer to through these experiences. Maybe for a romantic relationship, the initial component is more important. Then there are long marriages where people end up loving each other anyway; that's another thing. I don't know; it's very complicated, this question. I'll let you sort all this out. It's good that you recorded it.

I: We know there are different ways to love, and so I'd like you to talk about how you know your partner loves you.

P: Yeah, there's a very concrete example. I know she loves me because she took a train for, I can't remember if it was [6-10] hours or more. Basically, she traveled from [City] to [City] to come and cheer me on at the [City] marathon. That's something I don't think many people would do. She knew it was important to me and came to support me, just like my father did for that race. We live in [City], [Country], originally, and my parents came to [City], [Country], for the marathon. Even though he was [76-80] at the time, he managed to walk from one point to another to see me several times and cheer me on by shouting my name. Combined with the emotions of the race, the effort, and being in a country I love, it's a very memorable memory. At that moment, it was impossible to doubt her love because, really, who does that? Who travels in an uncomfortable train journey just to cheer at a marathon? It's not an incredible event unless you're running. So yeah, it's an act of altruism without ever telling me, "Remember, I came to see you, so now..." without expecting anything in return. I think that's a very concrete event that shows her love. There are others in the same vein, maybe not as obvious, but on a daily basis, there are small events like that. For instance, encouraging me to come here in general. The act of encouraging someone altruistically, even if it complicates their own daily life a bit, is a gesture of love. So support in projects, paying attention to each other, but attention that matters to the

other person. That's the key, because I could bring a bouquet of flowers every night, and who cares. I think this is important; some couples might think that giving a little gift is the best way to show love, and it might work for some people. We're all sensitive to different things, but it's about finding what touches the other person and showing affection in that way, something that specifically pleases the other person.

I: I'd like you to talk about one of the latest positive interactions you had with your partner.

P: I'd say the voice messages we send each other. They count a lot for me. There are things I tell her about American life and her experiences here a few years ago when she came for her studies. So sharing that is interesting for her, seeing me in a situation she was in a few years ago. There's a certain complicity around that. Other positive moments were during Christmas vacation, for example, when we went to the mountains to ski with her mother, brother, and his girlfriend. Those were moments of complicity, which I'd like to have more of. This year, because of work, there were several occasions to spend more time with family that I couldn't take because I was busy in [Country]. These moments reinforce the complicity, understanding a bit where she comes from, significant events in her childhood, etc. [Event] vacation was part of that, and another voice message she sent after watching a movie that moved her deeply and that she wants to watch with me. Sharing her emotions right after the movie, almost as if we had watched it together, also shows this complicity, especially in a voice message.

I: So what made these interactions positive was the complicity?

P: Yeah.

I: On the contrary, I'd like you to talk about one of the latest negative interactions you had.

P: One of the latest negative interactions? I'd say there haven't been many negative interactions recently. When we're both tired, we might react differently, but they aren't recent. Do you want the last one?

I: Yeah, if there is one.

P: I think... well, negative, yes, it was certainly negative. I had this idea for an exchange program somewhere; I didn't know where yet. There were [1-5] possible labs, including one in [City] where she lives, another here in the [University], and one in the [Country]. I was a bit caught up in deciding where to go, and it was complicated to talk about my possible departure. It wasn't easy. Even after it became certain, it was hard for her to talk about it. I think she didn't really want to tell me how she felt about my departure because it made her sad. She doesn't like showing vulnerability. For example, if we're hiking and she falls and gets a cut, she doesn't want me to bandage it; she just wants to keep walking as if nothing happened. I think it's the same with my departure. When I tried asking how she felt about it, she just said she didn't want to talk about it, and I could see it made her very sad. It was complicated to talk about my possible departure before writing the project because I wasn't sure it would work. When I told her I might go to a lab in [City], she said, "No, you shouldn't come to [City]; you should go elsewhere." It seemed strange to me. So, there were moments where we were clumsy in discussing my

departure. We're much better at handling things now that I'm gone, but there were a few negative interactions before I left and before the project was written. There were feelings of sadness that emerged. These experiences made me realize I need to be more attentive and better at discussing future events, even if they're hypothetical.

I: And why do you think these were negative interactions?

P: They were negative because I feel like I could have handled things better. We learn from these unpleasant or negative moments, realizing we can hurt the other person. I think that's what happened—I wasn't very supportive in communicating about it because I had my own reservations about whether it would work or not. The negative part is that I didn't proactively decide and communicate my decision to her, which hurt her.

I: So, the lack of communication. I'd like you to talk about the challenges in your relationship.

P: Challenges... well, typically being able to communicate about such things. It's not very specific to our relationship. There's the future, work, where we'll settle, defining our priorities. We both need intellectual stimulation and to feel useful at work, and we need to be professionally fulfilled. But we're not solely career-focused people; we have other desires. We don't want to work like crazy and then realize we only did that. We have many other desires, so we'd like to find a balance. It sounds like we want everything, so we'll have to figure out how to achieve that balance. I think that's a challenge. She's settled in [City], and I'm not settled anywhere. We'll have to communicate well to organize ourselves and make decisions, planning around where we want to live most of the time and where our work takes us. This is a challenge many people our age face, but it's our next challenge: organizing future projects.

I: Are there challenges you've already overcome in the past?

P: She has two jobs, one 50% in [Country] and one 50% in [City], [Country]. So, she commutes [1-5] weeks in [City], [1-5] weeks in [Country]. I was based in [City] until I came here. It's mostly a challenge for her because I'm always happy when she comes, a bit sad when she goes back to [City]. Before my experiments, I could go to [City] a few times, less this year because I had to be in [Country] for the experiments. Even though she's starting to feel the fatigue from commuting, she wants a single position. It's a challenge we've overcome, but we still have more challenges ahead.

I: Continuing on the topic of challenges, we know relationships aren't always smooth. There are conflicts and disputes. I'd like to know about conflicts in your relationship: their frequency and subjects.

P: Their frequency is rare. Conflicts are really rare, probably due to both our personalities. I've had few conflicts in my relationships because I'm calm, etc. There have been some conflicts, usually due to fatigue, making us less patient and more on autopilot. I remember one during a hike. It was a long hiking day, and we were tired. It wasn't even about the direction to take; it was about how much further we had to walk. She wasn't happy with how I conveyed the information from the map. She took the map from me, and we had a little tiff. It was something

small. I got a bit stubborn, and we ended up discussing why I got stubborn and why she said certain things. We quickly moved past it and continued our hike. It was a brief moment of bad mood, but we talked it through. Conflicts are often small like this. Besides not immediately mentioning or owning my decision to come here, I don't recall major conflicts. Maybe she can tell you more.

I: If that's all that comes to mind, that's fine. So, communication problems that you resolve through communication.

P: Yes, absolutely. She's very good at that, partly because she studied psychology and went through therapy for several years. Beyond that, she's very perceptive, making it easy to revisit what went wrong if she wants to. As I said, if it reveals her vulnerability, it's more delicate.

I: I'd like to know, apart from communication, how you maintain your relationship.

P: I don't know if there are specific strategies like that. I think if it's a good relationship, it maintains itself, perhaps a bit optimistic. But just being attentive to certain things, wanting the same things, spending time together, discussing how vacations went, whether we enjoyed going to [Country] with friends, and if we'd do it again. Simply living experiences and discussing them helps maintain the relationship. Now that I'm here, we have calls and messages, and she's coming mid-[Month] and after I finish my work in [Month] for vacations. Planning things we both look forward to is necessary and sufficient to maintain and care for the relationship. Spending time together and planning projects together is essential.

I: On the contrary, I'd like to know what could make you leave your partner.

P: I think... you've probably heard this a lot, but control is a big no-no, but that won't happen with her. I can't imagine her suddenly becoming controlling. Not loving each other anymore is another risk, and no one is immune to that. If it happens, it will be extremely sad, but there's nothing much to do about it. Infidelity is also a factor. It's funny because I've discussed this with friends, imagining a partner spending lots of time in a book club with someone else. You might wonder if there's more complicity there. So, if we no longer have common desires, if we spend more time with others than together, it's similar to not loving each other anymore. Infidelity, even a one-night stand, could be a deal-breaker for me. I wouldn't want to compromise on that. If I'm committed and don't cheat, I expect the same. But, I think the biggest risk is diverging desires, where one of us can't follow the other anymore.

I: Yes, so diverging desires or lack of love. Do you think this relationship is good for you?

P: Yes, absolutely, otherwise, I wouldn't be in it.

I: Do you feel it helps you in your functioning and achieving your goals?

P: Yes, having more confidence in myself and being able to thrive.

I: Do you have an example of a situation where you felt this?

P: Yes, professionally, like coming to the [Country], supporting me or tolerating my curiosity and exploration, encouraging my running, even when the alternative is spending time with her. All this makes me feel she helps me achieve my goals and remain true to my priorities.

I: Do you feel like the same person or have you changed since being in this relationship?

P: For many things, I'm the same person, but there are things I embrace more now. I have more confidence and pay more attention to others, influenced by her attentiveness, which is somewhat new for me.

I: So, more self-awareness and confidence?

P: Yes, I learn a lot from her. I remember once discussing how I like to learn from people's behaviors. She said if I learned everything about her, our relationship would end, but I don't think it works that way. I'm always surprised by her behavior with people, and I can't fundamentally change to be like her, but I can nuance my reactions.

I: Regarding your partner, do you think she has changed?

P: There are many things, like her being more assertive, having more confidence in what she wants professionally. She remains very attentive and sensitive but maybe puts herself first more now, which is normal in professional development. I can't say for sure how much our relationship influenced this, but she's definitely evolving.

I: Do you feel safe in this relationship?

P: Yes, completely, because I can talk to her about anything without being judged.

I: Do you have an example of such a situation?

P: The current situation, being away, is a big test, but I don't doubt we'll stay together, and she'll visit, and it'll be great. I'm very calm about it, not anxious that the relationship will end or that she'll get tired of it. That's my example.

I: Finally, let's quickly address another dimension of relationships, sexuality. We know it's more or less important for different people. How does sexuality fit into your relationship?

P: I think we've had different experiences with sexuality. For me, it's important as an intimate moment. If you asked me [1-5] year ago, I'd say it was more important. But now, with the distance, it's not as important. When we're together, it remains important, and I have a strong desire for her. I think she desires me too, but it's more ceremonial or ritualistic for her. We need to discuss this more because she's generally not very comfortable or confident in this area. So, while it's important, it's not the primary thing, and there's a lot for us to explore together, which I think will be beneficial.

I: Are you satisfied with your sex life?

P: Yes, yes, I am.

I: Finally, I'll present a scale for you to rate. Let's see... can you see it?

P: Yes, it's coming up.

I: From 1 to 9, how much do you feel your partner truly listens to you?

P: I'd say 8.

I: Why 8?

P: Because she generally listens well, except when she's really hungry or tired.

I: Can you give an example?

P: From one conversation to the next, she remembers things I've said, showing I wasn't talking to a wall.

I: And from 1 to 9, how much does your partner generally listen to your needs?

P: I'd say 7. Very true, because she does listen to my needs, but I'm hesitant to say 9 completely true. If someone answers completely true, it might imply the other person sacrifices their own needs, which isn't the case, and that's good.

I: And how satisfied are you with your relationship overall, from completely dissatisfied to completely satisfied?

P: I'd say very satisfied or completely satisfied, but there are things I could have done better in the past and want to improve in the future. Completely satisfied might imply there's nothing to improve or be attentive to, which would be false, even though compared to other relationships, I'm completely satisfied.

I: Finally, if you had to rate your satisfaction with this relationship from 0 to 10?

P: It's a similar question. I'd say 10.

I: Why 10 and not 9?

P: Because there are these three essential things: communication, sharing, and individual freedom. Even if every interaction isn't a 10 out of 10, the desire to communicate, share, listen, have projects together, and pursue individual goals makes me completely satisfied.

I: Okay, very well. I'll stop here and end the recording.